



<< SHOBHAA DE

THE GREAT GREED CREED

Welcome to the banquet world. From a begging bowl to a 10-course repast, India now makes appetising news.

It began with fireworks. Literally. At least, for me. We were in Goa to greet the new century...the new millennium, for God's sake. How else could 2000 begin but with the sky exploding in technicolour? There was an irrational, absurd sense of euphoria. It was a naïve, trusting, touching belief that somehow everything would sort itself out. I was ready to believe in magic...miracles. The world was not going to the dogs. India was not going to the dogs. This was a cosmic moment. Everything would turn out just fine.

A few hours after the fireworks, in true Goa style, a few "believers" gathered at the edge of a very calm sea, to participate in a pre-dawn *havan*. We were bleary-eyed and champagned-out, but not entirely wasted. Determined to salute the first sunrise of a brand new century, we faced the east and raised our expectant faces to greet the pale pink orb, emerging at its own pace from behind low hills in the distance. We prayed our own personal prayers as priests chanted in unison. A bright and beautiful dawn smiled down on us. On the world. It was a moment.

Little did we imagine then that it would turn out to be India's moment very shortly after that poetic opening scene. Today, as we negotiate our way past the half-way mark of the current decade, that heady, euphoric New Year's Day feeling continues to enchant, seduce and intoxicate. India is a moveable feast. Welcome to the banquet, world. Strange irony. From begging bowl to a 10-course repast, we sure have come a long way. Never mind the downside. Let's not spoil the party with unappetising news. Why burst the bubble? India is on a roll and

the momentum continues to gather speed, much to the disappointment of doomsday prophets, who'd rather crow, "I told you so", if the fairytale turns into a nightmare. As of now, there aren't too many ogres in sight, and let's not give Narendra Modi that dubious honour, please. Like any ambitious global player competing for a large slice of the yummy pie, India too is busy stuffing its face and gobbling what it can. Why not? Brand India has finally shown the needed courage to abandon outdated socialist double standards and embrace aggressive international strategies designed to propel the country into the big boys' club. Ten years ago, we'd have been hooted (and booted) out of this elite club of developed nations, and reminded about our lowly place ("Down, boy") in the pecking order. It's a dramatically different story now, and the smart thing to do is to cash in on current perceptions. Whether India is merely poised, shining, glowing or growling, nobody will argue that India is certainly climbing, clambering, clawing its way to the top of the heap. About time, too. The only question worth asking is: what took us so long?

It has become trendy for some self-appointed critics to trash the newly brash India. The present, unapologetically brazen one that does not shy away from wearing

its success on its sleeve. But why? What are we afraid and/or ashamed of? Could the answer be, ourselves? The single biggest change in the India story has been in the area of self perception. We have finally stopped seeing ourselves as perennial losers waiting for handouts from the first world. The elephant has stirred out of the sanctuary and has decided to play the 'size does matter' game on its own terms.

**Nobody will argue
that India is
certainly climbing,
clambering,
clawing its way to
the top of the heap.**